In later years, US Ambassador to East Berlin, Richard C. Barkley, recalled one of the ‘more interesting things’ was the so-called diplomatic hunt where the entire politburo and members of the local establishment went out to shoot rabbits in the outback. ‘It was a tradition, an old German, almost pagan, tradition in that you blow horns for the hunt, and you sing the songs of the hunt,’ Barkley explained. He remembered one such trip near Erfurt:

They took us in, and they gave us boots and everything. Everything was courtesy of the East German army. The East Germans actually, had developed one of the best shotgun industries in the world at that time. So, we were all given shotguns etc, and we had a ‘minder’, a hunter who had dogs and all. It started out the previous night with a big banquet. It was a social event; it was not a political event. But obviously at the same time, you could see that there was a political pecking order. Not only in terms of who sat at what tables but where people were. The next day we went out and shot rabbits. Actually, the organisation was quite remarkable. The East Germans were known to be able to do that kind of local organisation. For example, when we got off the train there was a huge crowd cheering the diplomats. It was interesting to watch because diplomats are seldom cheered. There were these rather silly grins on most of these people’s faces as we walked along the tarmac and we were cheered heartily. Anyway, the next day, the politburo came out first led by Honecker. He could see a number of them were not enthusiastic hunters, but Honecker was. They were all dressed of course in their hunting gear. I noticed that those with the finest headgear were the highest-ranked in the politburo. Honecker had this sort of sable Russian hat. It turned out they went over to one section, and then sent the diplomats out into the fields as sort of beaters. We would march across the fields and rabbits would take off. They had been breeding rabbits there for a long time, so there were lots of them. They would run over the hill and who was there, over the hill shooting them as they came down the line but Erich Honecker and his troops. We were slogging through the mud. I remember what a really gory day it was. It was unforgettable in the sense that you were thrown together in a sort of ancient ritual and watched these so-called modern people engage in this ritual with great joy. I understand that Honecker of course, this will not surprise you, killed more